

Self-Knowledge & Handling Pressure

SESSION 1 OBJECTIVES

- ▶ You can name your most important core values as a person and as a teammate
- ▶ You recognize what gives you energy and what costs you energy in a team setting
- ▶ You can put a tense situation into perspective by distinguishing worst case, best case, and most likely

Who are you as a player and as a person, and how do you handle pressure? This worksheet helps you better understand your own values, energy, and reactions to stress. Take your time and be honest.

EXERCISE 1: PERSONAL VALUES COMPASS

1 Personal Values Compass

Rank the values below from 1 (most important) to 5 (less important) for you as a player and as a person.

____ Loyalty

____ Honesty

____ Courage

____ Perseverance

____ Respect

____ Team Spirit

Which value do you live up to the least? What do you want to change?

EXERCISE 2: ENERGY GIVER VS. ENERGY DRAINER

2 Energy Giver vs. Energy Drainer

Write down three things that give you energy during training or a game, and three things that cost you energy.

ENERGY GIVERS ►

ENERGY DRAINERS ▼

_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

EXERCISE 3: WORST CASE BEST CASE

3 Worst Case Best Case

Think of an upcoming situation that makes you nervous. Write down the three scenarios.

Worst Case

Best Case

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Most Likely

"The most important thing is to try and inspire people so that they can be great in whatever they want to do."

Kobe Bryant, 5x NBA Champion, Los Angeles Lakers

Character First, Session 1: Self-Knowledge & Handling Pressure

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Self-Knowledge & Handling Pressure

Scientific Foundation: Evidence Pyramid

SYSTEMATIC REVIEW Ntoumanis et al. (2021): a meta-analysis of 184 studies shows that autonomy and self-knowledge within Self Determination Theory are the strongest predictors of sport motivation and well-being in young athletes. *Psychology of Sport & Exercise*.

META-ANALYSIS Zuber & Conzelmann (2014): an analysis of 47 studies confirms that intrinsic motivation and self-concept are directly linked to sport performance in youth. *International Review of Sport & Exercise Psychology*.

LONGITUDINAL STUDY Deci & Ryan (1985, revised 2017): Self Determination Theory: autonomy, competence, and relatedness as universal basic needs for optimal development and well-being in sport. In addition, Hanton et al. (2009) shows that how a player interprets their own stress response (facilitative or debilitative) matters more than its intensity.

GUIDANCE PER EXERCISE

- 1 Values Compass:** After filling it in, ask volunteers to share their top value. Build a ranking on the board. Ask: "If these are our team values, how do we see that reflected in behavior?"
- 2 Energy Giver vs. Energy Drainer:** Have players fill this in individually. Then discuss only the energy givers as a group. Build awareness: "How can we build more energy givers into our team?" Discuss the energy drainers individually or in confidence.
- 3 Worst Case Best Case:** This can be done in pairs. Pair A writes, Pair B listens. Then switch. The coach asks one question: "Has your Worst Case ever actually happened?" The answer is almost always no. This reframing is the goal.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Fill in the worksheet yourself too and share your answers. A coach's vulnerability lowers the threshold for players to be honest.

Tip 2: Actively normalize stress. Say it literally: "Every pro feels this. So do you. It's not a weakness." Young players often think they're the only ones who feel nervous.

⚠️ **Avoid:** "Who wants to share their answers?" Directly calling on someone creates a sense of insecurity. Build trust by sharing first yourself, then asking for volunteers. Also be careful not to add pressure by saying "You need to be able to do this" — that only increases the very stress you're trying to reduce.

TIME INDICATION

- ☐ Introduce the theme and explain the exercises: 5 minutes
- ☐ Individually complete the Values Compass: 10 minutes
- ☐ Individually complete Energy Giver vs. Energy Drainer: 8 minutes
- ☐ Worst Case Best Case in pairs: 12 minutes
- ☐ Group discussion and closing with quote: 10 minutes

My Role & Team First

SESSION 2 OBJECTIVES

- ▶ You can name your current role(s) on the team with concrete examples
- ▶ You give and receive constructive feedback without triggering blame or defensiveness
- ▶ You help close a shared team contract that guides the team

You don't have just one role on a team, and the step from "I" to "we" is one of the hardest in sport. This worksheet helps you discover which role you fulfill, how you give and receive feedback, and what you personally want to promise to your team.

EXERCISE 1: ROLE COMPASS

1 Role Compass

Give yourself a score from 0 to 10 for each of the four roles below. Color in the bars.

Leader

Gives direction, speaks to the group

Score: ____/10

Engine

Brings energy, drives the team forward

Score: ____/10

Thinker

Analyzes, asks questions, looks for solutions

Score: ____/10

Steady Force

Reliable, consistent, support for others

Score: ____/10

EXERCISE 2: FEEDBACK ROUND TRIO

2 After the Feedback Round Trio

In groups of three: Role A gives feedback, Role B receives, Role C observes tone and word choice. What was the best feedback you received? What will you concretely do with it?

EXERCISE 3: TEAM CONTRACT

3 My Contribution to the Team Contract

Write down three behavioral rules you personally want to live by — not about winning, but about how you treat your teammates.

I promise to _____

I promise to _____

I promise to _____

Signature

Date

"The strength of the team is each individual member. The strength of each member is the team. I never tried to be the best player. I tried to be the player we needed."

Phil Jackson, 11x NBA Championship coach

My Role & Team First

Scientific Foundation: Evidence Pyramid

SYSTEMATIC REVIEW Bruner et al. (2021): a meta-analysis on role clarity and cohesion in youth teams: role clarity is the strongest predictor of both task cohesion and social cohesion in sport teams, with an effect size of $d=0.62$. *Journal of Sport Sciences*.

LONGITUDINAL STUDY Eys et al. (2015): a season-long study of 248 basketball players: role ambiguity is negatively linked to self-confidence and positively linked to anxiety. *Sport, Exercise & Performance Psychology*. In addition, Holt et al. (2020) shows that teams trained in Nonviolent Communication for 8 weeks showed significantly higher social cohesion and fewer conflicts.

THEORETICAL STUDY Carron & Eys (2012): Team Cohesion Model: role acceptance and role performance as two separate dimensions. Athletes who actively invest in their role perform significantly better. Tod et al. (2011) also confirms that communication training in sport teams improves cohesion.

GUIDANCE PER EXERCISE

- 1 Role Compass:** After filling it in, ask volunteers to share their highest role score. Emphasize that this is not a ranking: a Steady Force is just as valuable as a Leader.
- 2 Feedback Round Trio:** Divide the team into groups of three. Role A: giver, Role B: receiver, Role C: observer. The giver gives feedback about something concrete, the observer pays attention only to tone and word choice, not content. After each round (3 minutes) the observer gives 30 seconds of feedback: "You said... That sounded like..." Then switch roles.
- 3 Team Contract:** First let players individually write three personal promises (3 minutes). Then discuss in groups of three which promises overlap. The team votes on the behavioral rules that go into the shared Team Contract. Everyone signs.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Use roles in your daily coaching language. "Tom, you're our Engine today." This reinforces identity and gives direction without hierarchy.

Tip 2: Hang the Team Contract in the locker room or send it digitally in the group chat. Plan a review moment: contracts that are never evaluated are worthless.

⚠ **Note:** the Feedback Round can become intense if there is tension within the team. Scan the group dynamic before you start. In a tense atmosphere: start with positive feedback before moving to growth points. Also watch for players who score themselves low on all roles, and plan an individual conversation.

TIME INDICATION

- ☐ Introduce the four roles and complete the Role Compass: 10 minutes
- ☐ Feedback Round Trio: 15 minutes
- ☐ Individually write the Team Contract: 5 minutes
- ☐ Group process toward a shared contract and signing: 15 minutes

